

SLEF TRANSCENDENCE

Preamble

- One of the outcomes of such a phenomenological analysis of the being of humans is the truth that humans can go beyond themselves through a process of *self-transcendence* since they are incarnate spirits trending towards the Infinite.
- This section of the course examines the veracity of the latter claim as it discusses how self-transcendence (including its ultimate goal, intrinsic and extrinsic principles) presupposes the spirituality of human beings and how it is present at every level of human self-actualization.
- The discussion begins with a clarification of some terms in general.

The Phenomenon of Self-Transcendence

The notion of self-Transcendence

- The Latin cognate of the English term "transcendence" is *trans-scendere*, meaning "to ascend on," "elevate oneself above," "cross," "displace," "pass," "scale," etc.
- These definitions denote a spatial relation where a spiritual substance goes beyond its accidents.
- In philosophical anthropology, the term indicates "the property of a man by which he constantly goes beyond himself in all that he thinks, wills, and in all that he realizes (vertically or horizontally)" (Mondin 1985: 197).

Conceptual Clarification

- Some basic terms of great concern here include: "self-transcendence," "self-actualization," and "spirituality."
- The term "self-transcendence," refers to an agent's capability to rise above or extend notably beyond ordinary limits.
- The term "self-actualization," refers to the full realization of one's creative, intellectual, and social potential through an internal drive for intrinsic or extrinsic satisfaction.
- The term "spirituality," on the other hand, encompasses the recognition of a feeling or sense or belief that there is something greater than ourselves and something (cosmic or divine) the greater whole of which we are part.
- That means an understanding of the term "spirituality" is intrinsically connected to the being of a human agent.

- This standpoint underlines that humans constantly reach beyond their present reality due to their existence as spiritual beings open to God.
- This definition is compatible with the interpretation of "self-transcendence" before secularization in the modern era.
- In this era, the being and destiny of man depended on God and fate, which gave humans a sense of his self-transcendence on the vertical plane.
- However, with the elimination of fate and God, man became the determiner and master of his project.
- Hence, the emergence of other competing interpretations of self-transcendence on the horizontal plane.

Self-Transcendence and the Spirituality of Human Being

- The idea of a human being's spirituality emanates from the fact that human agents are constituted by something that evades the realm of matter, which propels them to go beyond themselves and something spiritual, the greater whole of which they are part.
- This feature and tendency of human agents to go beyond themselves make the discourse on self-Transcendence central in philosophical anthropology.
- Let us now discuss in detail the phenomenon of self-transcendence.

- We can deduce, therefore, disparate notions and types of self-transcendence, which encompasses humans' intrinsic ability to elevate themselves horizontally or vertically.
- What, then, is vertical and horizontal self-transcendence?
- A response to this question opens up the discussion on types of self-transcendence.

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Types of Self-Transcendence

- There are two types of self-transcendence, namely: vertical and horizontal self-transcendence.
- Vertical self-transcendence (also metaphysical self-transcendence) refers to humans' ability to push themselves higher beyond the limits of space and time towards the infinite.
- Some proponents of the vertical self-transcendence include some adherents of world-affirming religions, such as Judaism and Christianity.

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The Ultimate Goal of self-Transcendence

- The thrust of self-transcendence is to assuage humans' spatio-temporal and trans-temporal yearnings.
- The yearnings have three dimensions: egocentric, philanthropic, and theocentric yearnings.
- The thrust of human egocentric yearning in self-transcendence is to surpass the self to ensure its (i.e., the self) full realization in this spatio-temporal confines, with death as its only barrier.
- Nietzsche, for instance, argues that man must shatter the constraints of metaphysics, morals, religion, and the idea of God to realize himself fully or surpass himself. Consequently he declared God's death.

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- In contrast, horizontal self-transcendence (also historical self-transcendence) refers to humans' ability to progress towards the future but remain within space and time (Mondin 2019:197).
- The proponents of this stance include existentialists, Marxists and the adherents of withdrawal religions, like Hinduism and Buddhism.
- For instance, Buddhists and Hinduists construe self-transcendence as a state in which the soul becomes intuitively aware of itself.
- In other words, the reality of self-transcendence begins and ends with the self.

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- On the other hand, Heidegger presents one of the fundamental constituents of Dasein (i.e., man) as the ability of humans to go beyond (i.e., ex-sistens) their factual situation towards ulterior possibilities.
- So, Nietzsche and Heidegger construe the egocentric thrust of self-transcendence as a human effort to free "the self" from miseries by actualizing his possibilities.
- Surpassing oneself through self-transcendence helps him acquire a new level of knowledge, grades of culture, and well-being.
- Self-transcendence is not the immolation of the self but the research of a perfect being.

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- The notion of self-transcendence from an African worldview encompasses a kind of vertical movement that aims at reconciling any distorted harmony in the ontological hierarchy of being controlled by an all-pervasive vital force.
- Vertical or horizontal instances of self-transcendence have tripartite goals, as presented in the next section.

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- The Philanthropic thrust of self-transcendence aims at creating new humanity emancipated from individual miseries and social inequalities.
- Such emancipation requires humans' awareness of their incompleteness (Roger Garaudy), the ability to go beyond many situations (Herbert Marcuse), and the consciousness that the root of their self-transcendence lies in exploring the space of possibilities before them (Ernst Bloch).
- Humans' transitory and imperfect nature makes realizing this kind of self-transcendence unrealistic.

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- The *theocentric goal* of self-transcendence is feasible when humans go beyond their reality pushed by a superior will or God.
- This view represents a vertical or metaphysical notion of self-transcendence.
- Some proponents of this stance include Plato, Aristotle, Plotinus, Augustine, Thomas, Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz, Kant, Hegel, Bergson, Max Scheler, Blondel, Teilhard de Chardin, Karl Rahner, Gabor Boros, Thaddeus Metz, Bernard Lonergan, Emerich Coreth, Joseph de Finance, Wolfhart Pannenberg, etc.

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The principles of self-transcendence

- The whole discourse on self-transcendence is founded on two major principles: intrinsic and extrinsic.
- The *intrinsic basis* of the discourse on self-transcendence presents humans as a value in continual need of God to whom belongs 'essentially, naturally, and entirely the title of absoluteness' (Mondin 2019: 208). That means humans seek God since they possess an interior dimension of a spiritual nature.
- The *extrinsic principle* of self-transcendence refers to all those spatio-temporal elements at the substrate of the humans' effort to move beyond themselves.

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- Pannenberg, for instance, argued that the aim of self-transcendence is God.
- So, self-transcendence brings man back to God, the foundation of every sense and every wish.
- Engaging Pannenberg in critical dialogue, Godfrey Onah adds that humans participate with God in making history while going beyond themselves.
- In other words, they are active rather than passive participants in the whole process of self-transcendence since they come to the knowledge of God through self-knowledge and vice versa.
- Other proponents of the theocentric goal of self-transcendence argue that humans find the ultimate sense of their being in God.

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Resumé

- The phenomenon of self-transcendence helps humans to actualize themselves.
- In other words, self-transcendence leads to self-actualization or the maximization of humans' abilities, skills and potential.
- To understand how the phenomenon of self-transcendence engenders the latter, an exploration of the notion of "self-actualization" from the point of view of philosophical anthropology becomes exigent.

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- So, there is a spatio-temporal and trans-temporal thrust of self-transcendence.
- While the former has an extrinsic basis, the latter has an intrinsic ontological foundation.
- We now explore the foundational principles of self-transcendence in the next section.

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Self-Transcendence and Human Self-Actualization

- Humans' quest to fulfill their potential, especially their spatio-temporal and trans-temporal needs, is at the base of the discourse on self-actualization in philosophical Anthropology.
 - What, then, is self-actualization in philosophical Anthropology?
- The term "Self-Actualization" in Philosophical Anthropology.
- Self-actualization encompasses humans' inherent tendency to realize and utilize their extrinsic and intrinsic needs in developing their abilities, skills, and potential.
 - Some of the inherent tendencies through which humans actualize their spatio-temporal and trans-temporal (spiritual) needs when they go beyond themselves constitute the levels of self-actualization.

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Different Levels of Self-Actualization

- Humans realize their full potential while seeking to fulfill their spatio-temporal and trans-temporal needs (physiological, safety, affective, esteem, cognitive, and aesthetic needs).
- That means that self-actualization depends on fulfilling the abovementioned needs, which are far-fetched without life, knowledge, freedom, symbols like language, work, within cultural context, and self-consciousness and objectivity.
- We now examine the latter elements, which are fundamental in human self-actualization.

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- Fifth, self-actualization is impossible without freedom, which enables humans to be masters of some of their actions (*indeterminism*) and non-masters of other extrinsic and intrinsic actions that we do not have control over (*determinism*).

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- First, self-actualization is meaningless without the phenomenon of life since life is an essential activity of humans created by God and not reducible to a machine (vitalism), without which there cannot be any discourse on self-actualization and self-transcendence.

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- Sixth, self-actualization is intertwined with the phenomenon of culture since humans are cultural beings who can cultivate nature and profoundly transform and adapt it to meet their needs.
- Seventh, humans cannot actualize themselves and meet basic needs like food, houses, roads, clothing, etc., if they cannot work.
- That is why the phenomenon of work is fundamental to human self-actualization.

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- Second, there is also the phenomenon of language through which humans socialize, express themselves and show they belong to the world.
- So, language does not only represent but also functions as a medium for human self-realization.
- Third, the phenomenon of knowledge helps humans fulfill their cognitive needs as they use their external and internal senses (vision, hearing, taste, smell, touch/ common sense, memory, fantasy, and instinct) to acquire *sensitive knowledge* and *intellective knowledge* (coordination, classification, and generation of ideas, judgments, and reasoning).

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- Finally, humans cannot actualize themselves or be capable of self-transcendence if they are not imbued with self-consciousness and objectivity.
- Self-consciousness and objectivity refer to the *intentional disposition* of humans (i.e., direct or immediate or concomitant consciousness) towards the object they direct their gaze or perception while taking cognizance of themselves as the subject that accomplishes the action in question (i.e., reflexive or indirect consciousness).
- Animals lack the latter disposition.

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Summary

- Drawing on the above, it is evident that human self-transcendence leads to self-actualization.
- However, the latter is impossible without cognizance of the fundamental elements of the phenomenology of human action.

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Evaluation

- The discourse on self-transcendence above has not completely addressed the recurrent question about what human projection of themselves vertically and horizontally means.
- The discourse does not explain why humans engage in an endless vertical and horizontal movement beyond themselves and an endless quest for self-actualization.
- These are some obvious challenges associated with the ongoing discourse on self-transcendence in Philosophical Anthropology.

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Conclusion

- The discourse above explored the theme of "self-transcendence and the spirituality of the human being.
- It also stated the ultimate goal, intrinsic and extrinsic principles of self-transcendence, and how the reality of self-transcendence is present in every level of human self-actualization.